

PLSC 476: Empirical Legal Studies

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Are Lawyers Happy?

Popular press: No.

- More prone to anxiety, depression, substance abuse, suicide, etc., and
- Generally in denial about it
- Based largely on anecdotes + unscientific surveys

Scientific literature: More or less...

- Attorneys are similar to other professionals with respect to job satisfaction & subjective well-being
- Generally make use of *self-reported* measures
- Concerns:
 - Self-reporting → *adaptation*
 - Social desirability bias

Most common: Direct measures of concepts

Alternative: Indirect measures

- Multiple, incomplete/imperfect *indicators* of the concept +
- *Data reduction* to combine indicators into a single measure

Challenges:

- Indicators vary in *scale*
- Indicators vary in *relation to the underlying concept*
- Often hard to *validate*

- National sample of attorneys in the U.S.
- Three-wave panel, following ≈ 5000 attorneys who were first admitted to the bar in 2000
 - Wave I in 2002 ($N = 4538$)
 - Wave II in 2007 ($N = 3705$)
 - Wave III in 2012 ($N = 2862$)
- > 500 survey questions / items, on a wide range of topics
- We'll focus on Wave III $\rightarrow$ experienced attorneys

Satisfaction Index: Components

Q: How satisfied are you with each of the following aspects of your current position? [1 = “very dissatisfied” → 7 = “very satisfied”]

- Level of **responsibility** you have
- **Recognition** you receive for your work
- Opportunities for **advancement**
- **Compensation**
- Control you have over the **amount of work** you do
- **Intellectual challenge** of your work
- **Value** of your work to society
- **Balance** between personal life and work

Mean Attorney Satisfaction

Balance between personal life and work

Value of your work to society

Intellectual challenge of your work

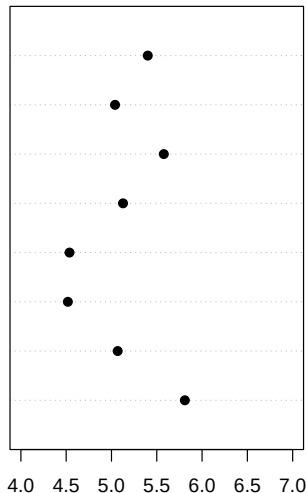
Control you have over the amount of work you do

Compensation

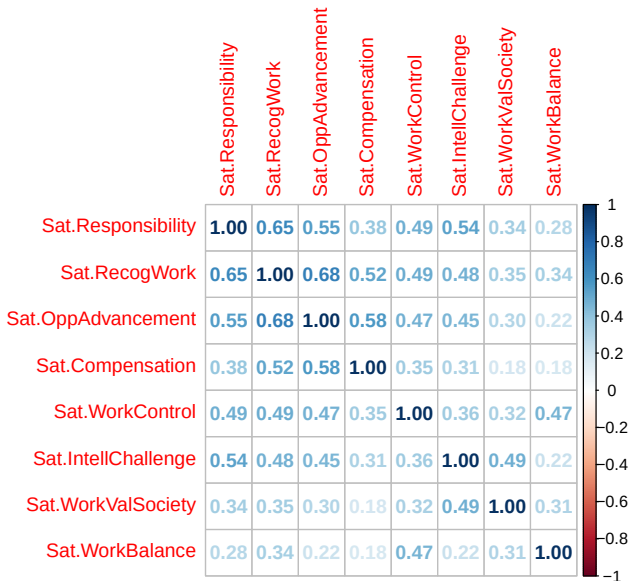
Opportunities for advancement

Recognition you receive for your work

Level of responsibility you have

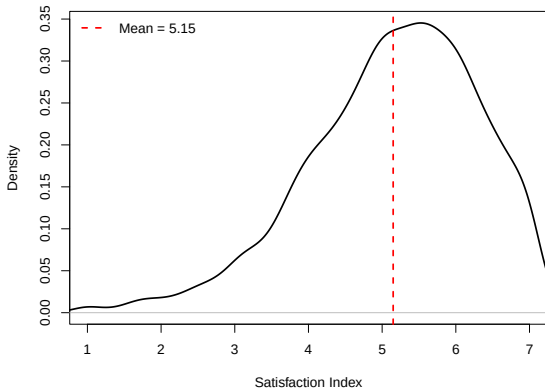


Satisfaction Components: Correlations



Summarizing Satisfaction: Additive Index

$$\text{Satisfaction}_i = \frac{\sum_{j=1}^8 \text{Satisfaction Component}_{ij}}{8}$$

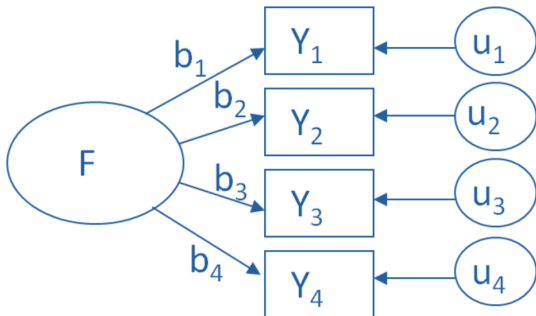


Data Reduction: Factor Analysis

Factor analysis (FA) is a model for the measurement of a latent variable using manifest / observable indicators.

- Observable indicators are manifestations of one or more latent / unobservable *factors*
- Extant indicators are differentially caused by the latent factor(s), and are observed with error
- The goal of FA is to derive measures of the latent factor from the observed data, by estimating factor *loadings* (associations between latent factors and observable variables)

Factor Analysis, Conceptually



$$Y_1 = b_1 F + u_1$$

$$Y_2 = b_2 F + u_2$$

$$Y_3 = b_3 F + u_3$$

$$Y_4 = b_4 F + u_4$$

Steps:

- Choose the *number of factors* (dimensions)
- Consider *rotation*
- *Estimate* the factor loadings
- *Interpret* the factors...
- Generate *factor scores*: Values of the latent factor(s)

Lawyer Satisfaction: Factor Analysis

```
> SatFA<-factanal(AJD[complete.cases(AJD[,SatVars]),SatVars],factors=1,  
+               na.action=na.omit,rotation="varimax",scores="regression")  
> SatFA
```

Call:

```
factanal(x = AJD[complete.cases(AJD[, SatVars]), SatVars], factors = 1, na.action = na.omit,  
        scores = "regression", rotation = "varimax")
```

Uniquenesses:

Sat.Responsibility	Sat.RecogWork	Sat.OppAdvancement
0.435	0.290	0.389
Sat.Compensation	Sat.WorkControl	Sat.IntellChallenge
0.642	0.613	0.625
Sat.WorkValSociety	Sat.WorkBalance	
0.793	0.840	

Loadings:

	Factor1
Sat.Responsibility	0.752
Sat.RecogWork	0.843
Sat.OppAdvancement	0.782
Sat.Compensation	0.598
Sat.WorkControl	0.622
Sat.IntellChallenge	0.612
Sat.WorkValSociety	0.455
Sat.WorkBalance	0.400

	Factor1
SS loadings	3.373
Proportion Var	0.422

Test of the hypothesis that 1 factor is sufficient.

The chi square statistic is 918.1 on 20 degrees of freedom.

The p-value is 1.09e-181

Predicted score on the underlying concept / factor:

$$\hat{S}_i = f[Y_{1i}\hat{b}_1 + Y_{2i}\hat{b}_2 + \dots + Y_{ki}\hat{b}_k]$$

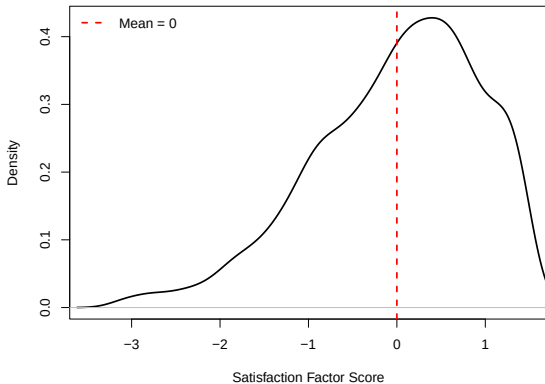
Factor scores:

- Are measures of each observation's value on the underlying factor **F**
- Account for the degree of association between each indicator *Y* and the underlying factor
- Are “scale-free”:
 - Mean = 0
 - Variance = 1
 - (Typically) Normally distributed

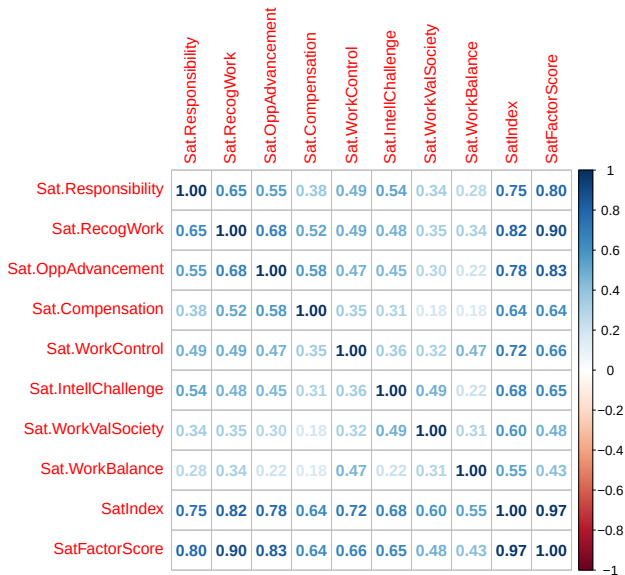
Factor Scores in Practice

```
> describe(AJD$SatFactorScore)
```

	vars	n	mean	sd	median	trimmed	mad	min	max	range	skew	kurtosis	se
X1	1	2341	0	0.94	0.13	0.07	0.96	-3.08	1.42	4.5	-0.66	0.08	0.02

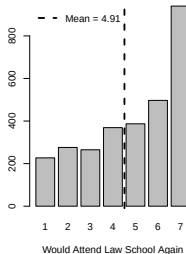
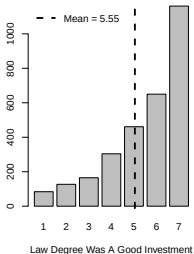
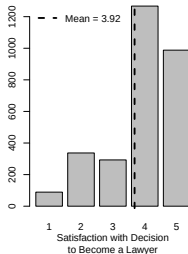


Comparisons

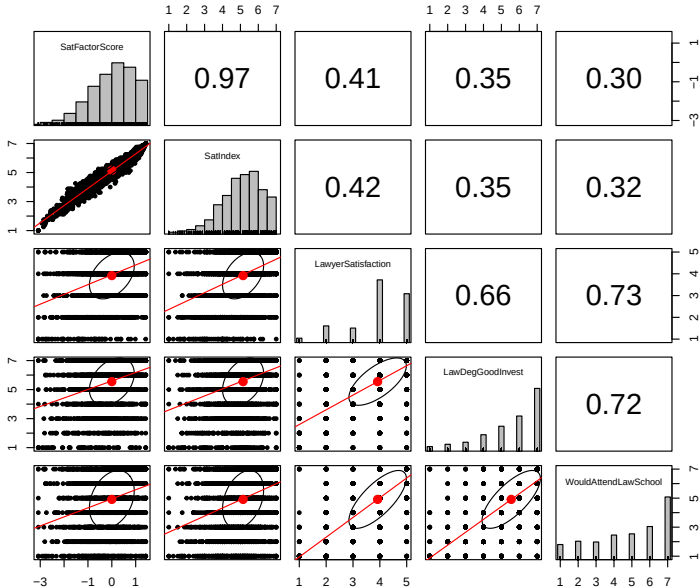


Validation: Direct Measures of Satisfaction

1. How satisfied are you with your decision to become a lawyer? [1 = “very dissatisfied” → 5 = “very satisfied”]
2. Indicate your level of agreement [7 = “strongly agree”] or disagreement [1 = “strongly disagree”] with the following statements about your legal education:
 - a. I consider my law degree to have been a good career investment
 - b. If I had to do it over again, I would still choose to have gone to law school



Comparison: Factor Scores and Direct Measures



Drivers of Lawyer Satisfaction

Potential influences:

- Years In Current Position
- Hours Worked Per Week (ordinal: 0-20, 21-40, 41-60, 61-80+)
- Educational Debt (ordinal, 8 categories)
- Female vs. Male
- Race/Ethnicity
- Age (≤ 35 , 36-40, ≥ 41)

Regression Analyses

	<i>Lawyer Satisfaction</i>	
	Factor Score	Direct Measure
Year Started at Employer (1970=0)	0.002 (0.005)	-0.014*** (0.005)
Hours Worked Per Week	-0.066** (0.030)	0.044 (0.030)
Educational Debt	-0.020** (0.009)	-0.039*** (0.009)
Female	-0.073* (0.041)	-0.030 (0.041)
African-American	-0.169** (0.078)	0.216*** (0.079)
Latino	0.054 (0.078)	0.279*** (0.079)
Native American	0.180 (0.329)	0.055 (0.308)
Asian	-0.047 (0.070)	-0.009 (0.071)
Other Race	-0.027 (0.098)	0.100 (0.096)
Age 36-40	-0.734 (0.928)	-0.074 (0.589)
Age 41+	-0.764 (0.928)	0.073 (0.589)
Constant	-3.871 (9.162)	32.060*** (9.192)
Observations	2,133	2,542
R ²	0.011	0.022
Adjusted R ²	0.005	0.018
Residual Std. Error	0.927 (df = 2121)	1.019 (df = 2530)
F Statistic	2.065** (df = 11; 2121)	5.205*** (df = 11; 2530)

Note: Cells are linear regression coefficients;
numbers in parentheses are standard errors.

* p<0.1; ** p<0.05; *** p<0.01

Summary: Factors Driving Lawyer Happiness

Key findings:

- Factors that contribute **positively** to lawyers' happiness / satisfaction include:
 - ... well... none?
 - *maybe* being African-American or Latino/a?
- Factors that contribute **negatively** to lawyers' happiness / satisfaction include:
 - Educational debt
 - Being female (?)
 - Hours worked (?)
 - More recent career start (?)
- Factors that seem not to matter include:
 - Age
 - Being Native American / Asian